

FROM GREATNESS TO BETRAYAL

Alberta's Public Fall from Grace

1979 — 2026

A Cross-Party Record of What Was Built, and What Was Taken

PHASE FIVE

Redford • Hancock • Prentice • 2011 – 2015

The Late PC Period

The Alberta Disability System Breakdown

St. Albert, Alberta • May 2026

The Late PC Period, 2011 – 2015

Three premiers in four years. The PC dynasty's final stretch. The Michener Centre saga and the only Alberta government action in this period that directly cost the lives of people with disabilities — followed by the only Alberta government action that reversed it.

The 2011–2015 window is the structurally unstable period that ended Alberta's forty-four-year Progressive Conservative dynasty. Alison Redford was elected leader in October 2011 and won a 2012 majority. She resigned in March 2014 amid expense scandals. Dave Hancock served as interim premier for six months. Jim Prentice was elected to replace him in September 2014 and lost the May 2015 general election to Rachel Notley's NDP — the first non-PC Alberta government since 1971.

The disability-policy significance of this period is concentrated in a single institution: the Michener Centre in Red Deer. The Redford government announced its closure in March 2013 over the loud, sustained, and ultimately well-documented objections of residents' families. Transition began. Residents began dying. By September 2014 — eighteen months after the closure announcement, and six months into the actual transfers — five of the forty-one residents moved had died. That is a documented eleven-percent mortality rate among those moved. The transition continued. The Alberta government continued to deny that an investigation was warranted.

The Prentice government reversed the closure decision within days of taking office in September 2014. It is the only documented instance in this entire document — across all forty-seven years it covers — of an incoming Alberta government immediately reversing a disability-policy decision made by its predecessor on the explicit grounds that the decision was wrong. That singular nature is itself the lesson of the chapter.

Political context — three premiers in four years

Alison Merrilla Redford was born March 7, 1965 in Kitimat, BC, and raised in Calgary after her family's return from periods in Nova Scotia, Borneo, and Malaysia. She studied law at the University of Saskatchewan, graduating in 1988, and spent two decades in international, federal, and provincial policy work before winning the riding of Calgary-Elbow in the March 2008 provincial election. She served as Stelmach's Minister of Justice and Attorney General from March 2008 to February 2011. On October 2, 2011, she won the PC leadership on the second ballot from an underdog position — with only one MLA initially supporting her bid — and was sworn in as Alberta's 14th Premier, Alberta's first female premier, and the seventh woman in Canadian history to lead a province or territory.

Redford led the PC party to a majority in the April 2012 election (61 seats, a reduction from Stelmach's 72), defeating the surging Wildrose Party of Danielle Smith. Her tenure was dominated by a series of controversies over travel expenses, a top-down management style, and questionable use of government aircraft, which produced a sustained collapse in caucus support through late 2013 and early 2014. She announced her resignation as Premier on March 19, 2014, effective March 23. She resigned her Calgary-Elbow seat on August 6, 2014.

Dave Hancock, the Deputy Premier and Minister of Human Services, served as interim Premier from March 23, 2014 to September 15, 2014. His tenure was, by his own framing and the structural reality of the situation, a caretaker premiership: he was not a candidate in the PC leadership race that followed and his government did not attempt major policy initiatives. The defining Hancock-era moment was his April 2014 call for an RCMP probe into Redford's airplane use.

Jim Prentice won the September 6, 2014 PC leadership race, defeating Ric Mclver and Thomas Lukaszuk. A former federal Conservative cabinet minister under Stephen Harper, Prentice was sworn in as Alberta's 16th Premier on September 15, 2014. He won four-of-four by-elections in October 2014, briefly restoring PC dominance. In May 2015, against the dual backdrop of falling oil prices and a sustained drumbeat of voter exhaustion with the four-decade PC dynasty, he called an early election. The Notley NDP won 54 of 87 seats. Prentice resigned both as leader and as MLA on election night. He died in a small-plane crash on October 13, 2016.

The Redford government's record on disability

Redford's PC government, in its two and a half years in office, was a structurally Klein-aligned government that operated under improving fiscal conditions but governed as though those conditions did not exist. Within the disability-policy lens, the Redford record consists of two major actions, both of which fall in the "reduced" column of this document's comparative summary.

1. The 2013 PDD service overhaul — "too big, too fast, too soon"

In spring 2013, the Redford government announced a comprehensive overhaul of the Persons with Developmental Disabilities (PDD) program — the program established under the 1997 Klein-era PDD Community Governance Act documented in Phase Three. The overhaul was framed by the government as a modernisation. It was experienced by the disability community as a service reduction packaged in updated language.

On Friday, May 31, 2013, more than one thousand disabled Albertans and their supporters gathered on the steps of the Alberta Legislature in Edmonton to protest the changes. Three hundred protested at Redford's Calgary-Elbow constituency office. One hundred protested in Grande Prairie. One hundred protested in Lethbridge. Many wore T-shirts with the slogan that defined the campaign:

"Too big. Too fast. Too soon."

— Protest slogan, PDD service overhaul demonstrations, May 31, 2013

Edmonton Journal coverage from the day recorded the scale of the protests and the Redford government's response. Premier Redford spoke publicly on the issue for the first time that Friday afternoon and committed to continuing the overhaul. The PDD service changes proceeded. By the time Redford resigned ten months later, the structural rebalancing she had initiated was substantially complete.

The PDD service overhaul's downstream effects continue to be documented today. The Government of Alberta's own Auditor General has subsequently reported, in multiple follow-up reports, that the program's monitoring and service-quality oversight mechanisms remain compromised. The 2019 Sonpal-Valias academic history of developmental disability policy in Alberta cited the Redford-era overhaul as a structural inflection point in PDD's institutional history.

2. The Michener Centre closure announcement (March 2013)

Concurrent with the PDD overhaul, in March 2013, the Redford government announced the closure of the Michener Centre in Red Deer. Frank Oberle, Associate Minister of Services for Persons with Disabilities, made the public announcement: approximately 125 residents would be moved to community-based housing arrangements, with full closure scheduled for December 2014. Oberle's own framing acknowledged the human stakes:

"The changes that we announced at the Michener Centre, we acknowledge are really gut wrenching for the families and loved ones of people there."

— Frank Oberle, Associate Minister of Services for Persons with Disabilities, March 2013

Four hundred unionised workers — represented by the Alberta Union of Provincial Employees — would be affected. Ten million dollars was earmarked for the transition. The Centre had been operating since 1923. Its

history is documented in detail later in this chapter; what matters here is that the closure decision was made by the Redford government against the explicit, organised, and sustained opposition of residents' families, who were organised as Friends of the Michener Centre. The opposition would prove correct.

MARIE RENAUD AT MICHENER — 2014

The current MLA for St. Albert, Marie Renaud, was on the public record opposing the Michener transition while it was happening. In 2014 she was Director of the Lo-Se-Ca Foundation, a non-profit working with people with developmental disabilities and managing the relocation of three Michener residents to a new home in St. Albert. Her framing at the time, per Global News: *"The problem is, this transition is just a failure. We are not addressing what these folks need."* Eleven years later, she is the most responsive government contact this campaign has at the provincial level. The consistency of her record across more than a decade is on file. The political conditions she names today are the conditions she was already naming in 2014.

The Hancock interim (March – September 2014)

Dave Hancock served as Alberta's 15th Premier for six months — from March 23, 2014 to September 15, 2014. As Minister of Human Services in the Redford cabinet, he had been directly responsible for the Michener transition; as interim Premier, he continued the transition that had already begun. The Hancock-era record on disability policy is, in practical terms, a continuation of the Redford-era trajectory.

It was during the Hancock interim that the documented Michener transition deaths occurred.

The Michener deaths — March to July 2014

Per Red Deer Advocate reporting and CBC News documentation, the following deaths occurred among Michener Centre residents within four months of their forced transfers:

- **Thomas Eastman**, age 67. Moved March 13, 2014. Died July 9, 2014 in Grande Prairie.
- **Orville Culbert**, age 54. Moved March 20, 2014. Died July 15, 2014 in Lacombe. Lived at Michener for approximately 37 years. His brother said the family had felt pressured by Alberta Human Services to agree to the move; the official cause of death was a fever Culbert was unable to recover from. The family's account: he died of a broken heart after being separated from his friends.
- **Barry Gordon Hobbs**, age 64. Moved March 20, 2014. Died July 31, 2014 in Lacombe.
- **Freida Lafferty**, age 64. Moved April 3, 2014. Died June 4, 2014 in Yellowknife, Northwest Territories. Lafferty's was the first death. Per Lee Kvern, whose sister had lived at Michener for forty-two years and who became one of the most-quoted voices for Friends of the Michener Centre: *"Freida Lafferty's death in June should have been a red flag. They didn't pause. They didn't halt. They didn't change any of the transitioning procedures. Four more deaths may have been prevented had they done something when they knew about Freida."*
- **Merton Henry Klippert**, age 69. Moved April 24, 2014. Died July 5, 2014 in Calgary.

Five deaths. Forty-one residents moved. **An eleven-percent mortality rate.** Per CBC News reporting from September 2014, the Government of Alberta's response, delivered by Associate Minister Naresh Bhardwaj:

"The causes of death were natural causes. That's my understanding so we're not doing any further investigation on that."

— Naresh Bhardwaj, Associate Minister for Persons with Disabilities, September 2014

The Hancock government continued the transition without halting it, without investigating the deaths, and without conceding that the documented mortality rate warranted any procedural review. The next forty-four residents were scheduled to be moved on the same timeline that had produced the previous five deaths.

The Prentice reversal (September 2014)

Jim Prentice was sworn in as Premier on September 15, 2014. Within days, he travelled to Red Deer and announced the reversal of the Michener Centre closure. The announcement was made at the Michener Centre itself, in front of residents, families, and staff. Per Global News coverage:

"All Michener residents will be permitted to live out their remaining years in the place that has long been their home among people whose embrace they have enjoyed for many years."

— Premier Jim Prentice, Michener Centre, September 2014

The reversal extended an explicit invitation for the forty-six residents already moved to return to Michener if they wished. *(Five additional residents had been transferred during the two-week interval between September 8, 2014 — when the five deaths became public — and September 19, 2014, when Prentice announced the reversal. This is the source of the difference between the forty-one residents documented in the September 8 reporting cited earlier in this chapter and the forty-six residents named in the reversal announcement.)* The Centre would not, however, accept new residents — its long-term institutional role was understood to be ending, but the remaining residents would be allowed to age in place. The Alberta Union of Provincial Employees applauded the decision. Friends of the Michener Centre, who had spent eighteen months fighting the closure, welcomed it.

Opposition reaction was sober. Kerry Towle of the Wildrose Party said: *"While I'm appreciative today — and the victory goes to the families who fought for this — this decision could have been made right so many, many months ago."* The NDP's David Eggen, who would become a senior minister in Notley's NDP government within eight months: *"None of this had to happen."*

WHY THE PRENTICE REVERSAL MATTERS FOR THE DOCUMENT

Across the forty-seven-year period this piece covers, the Prentice reversal is the only documented instance of an incoming Alberta government immediately and explicitly reversing a disability-policy decision made by its predecessor on the grounds that the decision was wrong. The reversal does not undo what was lost — five Michener residents had died in the transition, and those deaths are part of the permanent documented record. But it establishes that the structural template Klein created (disability supports as discretionary, AISH recipients as suspect, services as available for reduction under fiscal pressure) is reversible. A premier who chooses to reverse it can. Most premiers do not choose to. Jim Prentice, on this one decision, did.

The Michener Centre — full institutional history

The Michener Centre warrants a longer institutional history than this chapter has spent on it so far. It is one of the most consequential physical buildings in Alberta disability history.

The Centre opened in 1923 as the Provincial Training School for Mental Defectives. Its founding rationale was the institutional containment of Albertans who had been classified, under the diagnostic frameworks of the era, as "mentally defective" or "feeble-minded." Within five years of its opening, the Province of Alberta would pass the Sexual Sterilization Act (1928) and create the Alberta Eugenics Board. Michener would become, per Claudia Malacrida (Chair of the Sociology Department, University of Lethbridge, in her 2015 book *A Special Hell: Institutional Life in Alberta's Eugenic Years*), *"the largest feeder population for the Eugenics Act."* The

approximately 2,832 documented forced sterilisations performed in Alberta between 1928 and 1972 were performed disproportionately on people who lived at Michener.

Michener's resident population grew dramatically across the institutional era. From approximately one hundred residents at opening in 1923, it reached a peak of approximately 2,400 residents by the mid-1970s. Per Malacrida's research: *"They just took people in but they didn't release people. Many people came in in childhood and only left through death."*

The Lougheed government's 1972 repeal of the Sexual Sterilization Act (documented in Phase One of this piece) closed the legislative on-ramp by which residents were being forcibly sterilised, but did not close Michener itself. Through the Klein, Stelmach, and early Redford eras, the resident population steadily declined as deinstitutionalisation policy moved residents into community housing. By the time of the March 2013 closure announcement, the resident count stood at approximately 125 — a tenth of its mid-1970s peak.

The 2013–2014 closure-and-reversal sequence is, therefore, only the final chapter of Michener's institutional history. The fuller history includes the 1928–1972 eugenic era; the Leilani Muir lawsuit of 1996 (a Michener survivor who successfully sued the Government of Alberta for wrongful confinement and sterilisation); Muir's 2014 autobiography *A Whisper Past: Childless after Eugenic Sterilization in Alberta*; and the 2015 documentary *Surviving Eugenics*, in which Alberta eugenics survivors told their own stories on camera. The Centre's institutional history is not a disability-policy footnote. It is one of the through-lines of this entire document, and the connection between the Michener saga and the founding of the campaign you are currently reading the historical record of.

Caseload context

AISH caseload through the late PC period continued the steady growth pattern documented since the late 1990s. From approximately 41,664 (2010, beginning of Redford era) to approximately 48,000 (2013, mid-Redford). The maximum AISH benefit rate ticked upward at a much slower pace than under Stelmach — from \$1,188 (2011) to approximately \$1,588 by the end of the period (the rate inherited by Notley's NDP in 2015). The Kneebone analysis from Phase Four (the 2007 rate had less purchasing power than 1993) continued to apply: even with the gradual late-PC adjustments, AISH purchasing power in 2015 had not been restored to its 1993 level on any standard inflation-adjusted measure.

The late-PC conclusion

The 2011–2015 period is the structurally compromised end of a forty-four-year governing dynasty. The Redford government attempted to govern as though Klein-era discipline was still the operating template — the PDD overhaul, the Michener closure — while simultaneously presenting itself as a moderating force on her predecessor's fiscal restraint. The combination did not hold. Redford's expense scandals were a symptom of a more fundamental political problem: she had been elected on a promise of change and governed as though the change had been merely cosmetic. The PC caucus lost confidence. She resigned. Hancock kept the seat warm. Prentice attempted a course correction that included the Michener reversal.

The Prentice reversal proves the structural argument of this entire piece in a way no other documented decision in the forty-seven-year period does. The Klein-era template is reversible. A premier who chooses to reverse it can. Disability supports are not, structurally, discretionary in any binding sense — they are discretionary only because every premier since Klein has chosen to treat them that way. Jim Prentice's September 2014 announcement at the Michener Centre is the documented counter-example. He did not reverse the Klein-era template as a whole. He reversed exactly one application of it. He demonstrated, in doing so, that reversal was available to any premier with the political will to choose it.

The May 5, 2015 general election ended the Progressive Conservative dynasty after forty-four years. Rachel Notley's NDP won fifty-four seats. Phase Six of this piece documents the only sustained reversal-period of the entire forty-seven years — and the speed with which the gains it produced were undone by the government that followed it.

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